



OVERCROWDING

With a large population and a lack of flat land for settlement, Japan is a crowded country. Land is expensive, especially in the cities, and many people commute long distances to work. During rush hour, subway trains are so crowded that guards have to push commuters on board. The uncomfortable journeys that people endure inspired Japanese technicians to invent personal stereos so people could listen to music while traveling.

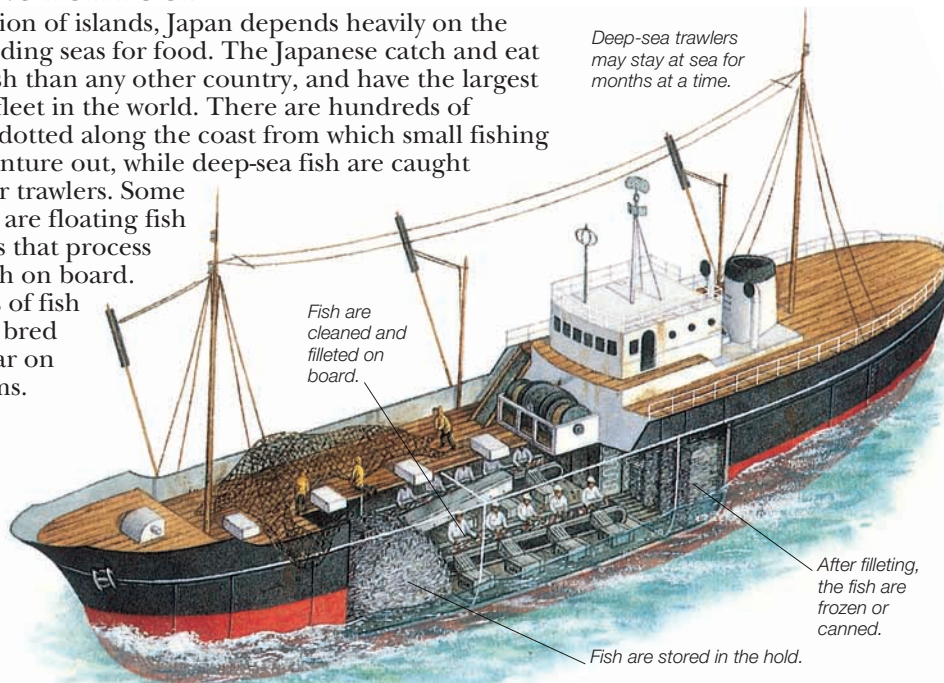


CHILDREN'S LIVES

Children are well taken care of in Japan. There is even a national holiday, Children's Day, dedicated to them. In another festival, "seven-five-three day," children are dressed in traditional clothing and taken to religious shrines. Japanese children are expected to study hard at school. In addition to a long school day, many pupils attend extra classes on Saturdays and in the evenings.

FISHING FOR FOOD

As a nation of islands, Japan depends heavily on the surrounding seas for food. The Japanese catch and eat more fish than any other country, and have the largest fishing fleet in the world. There are hundreds of villages dotted along the coast from which small fishing boats venture out, while deep-sea fish are caught by larger trawlers. Some trawlers are floating fish factories that process the catch on board. Millions of fish are also bred each year on fish farms.



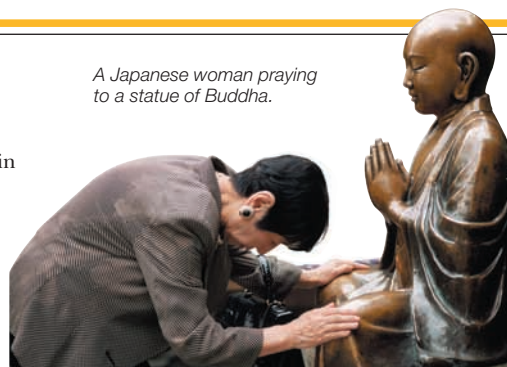
Fish are cleaned and filleted on board.

After filleting, the fish are frozen or canned.

Fish are stored in the hold.

RELIGION
Shinto and Buddhism, the two major religions of Japan, have always existed side by side and even merge together to a certain extent. Most Japanese people consider themselves Buddhist, Shintoist, or Shinto-Buddhist. There is also a significant Christian community, making it the third most popular religion in Japan.

A Japanese woman praying to a statue of Buddha.



FESTIVALS

There are plenty of festivals in Japan, each with their own emphasis and tradition. The parade shown here is from the Hakata Dontaku Festival in Kyushu, which is steeped in over 820 years of history. In the festival, Fukujin, Ebisu, and Daikoku, the three gods of good fortune, make the rounds of the city.



SPORTING LIFE

Whether watching or taking part, Japanese people love sports. The national team sport is baseball, which came to Japan from the US. An ancient sport unique to Japan is sumo wrestling. Success in the ring depends on weight and strength, so wrestlers follow high-protein diets.

Golf is popular in Japan. Practice ranges are often built on several levels to save space.



Many types of fish and seafood are eaten raw, as sushi, and artistically presented on lacquered dishes or trays.

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